

with the commission was forgotten, and I began to think Ms. Garrett and Prudential-Bache both had been underpaid.

Ms. Garrett said she'd be calling me with good news as well as bad, but I noticed we talked most often during this Angstrom surge, which started in December and continued into January. Though the stock had not yet reached the four-dollar level she'd predicted, my spirits were buoyed by her frequent mention of "an announcement of a big government contract" soon to come. She also sent me a copy of what may have been the one newspaper article written about the company: "Chemicals Key to Low-Cost Vision," which had appeared in *Automotive News*.

This article made me more confident than ever about Angstrom's prospects. From it, I learned that the company made chemical paints, visible under special light, something like the hand stamps used at racetracks and discotheques. Apparently, Angstrom's paint had attracted the attention of major tire companies, the U.S. Post Office, and dressmakers in Hong Kong. That Angstrom was expanding its markets without a sales department impressed me particularly.

Plus the fact I was at the laundromat one day and a copy of the *Wall Street Journal* had blown off a table, leaving a loose page with the word *Angstrom* staring me straight in the face. I'm not a superstitious person when it comes to investments. I've heard of people who tap the newspaper a certain number of times before turning to the stock tables, or who close their eyes and take furtive peeks at the daily quotations as if they've seen a train wreck, but I think they're silly. I'd be the first to agree that how you read a stock price has no effect on the actual ups and downs. But when the great U.S. financial journal spread open by itself on the laundromat bench below the soap dispenser, leaving "Angstrom, 2½ bid, 2⅝ ask" in plain view, it had to be a glorious omen. Four dollars per share seemed a certainty.

If only I could have shared my joy with Richard Bermont of Drexel Burnham Lambert—the man who in my private thoughts had become "the other broker." I still hadn't told him I'd opened a separate account and was dallying with a competitor. Sneaking around has become common investor practice. I'm told that thousands of clients at regular firms satisfy their wilder impulses with